



Becoming boundless: Indian transnational entrepreneurs in the global economy

by Manashi Ray, Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2026, 314 pp., \$130 (hardcover), ISBN 781503645387

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BOOK REVIEW

Becoming boundless: Indian transnational entrepreneurs in the global economy, by Manashi Ray, Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2026, 314 pp., \$130 (hardcover), ISBN 781503645387

In her seminal work, Manashi Ray offers a detailed, multi-layered exploration of the lives, networks, and structural contexts of Indian business migrants in the US. Ray, a sociology professor at West Virginia State University, draws on her extensive knowledge of migration, development, and ethnography to present an insightful analysis of highly educated, bicultural individuals navigating cross-border economic arenas, i.e. TEs. *Becoming Boundless* explores how contemporary global actors develop adaptable 'boundless' enterprises connecting the US, India, and other key global centres during a vital decade in India's post-reform era, thereby reshaping India's position in a multipolar world. The chapter highlights the diverse motives and experiences of Indians who migrate to the US, return, and engage in transnational entrepreneurship. This occurs amid shifting geopolitical dynamics and changing macro policies in India and the US at the height of globalisation. The analysis is based on around 60 in-depth interviews by the author, which she says made her 'feel optimistic about the promise and potential TES held for India's growth as an emerging economy in the twenty-first century'.

Ray's primary achievement is treating high-skilled migration not simply as a narrative of 'brain drain' or pure economic opportunism, but as a multifaceted sociocultural architecture underpinning transnational networks. The interviews reveal the varied reasons that motivated and mobilised men and women TE from different regions in India to migrate at different times from 1965 to the present. Many migrated to reinforce their social and economic status or to earn money. For others, migration meant gaining advanced technical skills, international experience, and education, or reuniting with partners or extended family. Some sought social protection, mobility, and economic security abroad. Despite their diverse social backgrounds and resource strategies across locations, all migration paths fuelled creativity and innovation in their transnational entrepreneurship. They actively used social and business networks between America and India.

Another remarkable insight the book offers is that transnational migration reconstitutes existing structures of historical inequality rather than completely dismantling them. Ray effectively combines her ethnographic and archival research with critical social theory – particularly Pierre Bourdieu's ideas of cultural and social capital – to explain how class, caste, and gender intersect in influencing who can cross geographical boundaries and succeed afterward. The invisibility of caste has historically played a key role in enabling TEs from traditional mercantile families, particularly in manufacturing, to achieve success and build wealth. Social networks naturally serve as mutual insurance systems to address market imperfections across borders, while also acting as central financial hubs and sources of information and contacts that support diverse transnational business activities. The book shows how TEs with higher caste membership directly offered opportunities to convert traditional capital into modern forms across various business sectors, even as TEs emphasise the decline of local caste hierarchies in favour of individualism and meritocracy. For example, chapter 2 demonstrates that studying TEs as both financial and symbolic capital is essential. This should be combined with social attributes such as caste, community, family, diasporic ties, religious affiliation, and gender relations to fully grasp the significance of TEs' resource advantages.

These cultural and social resources influence the development and sustainment of transnational networks, as well as enable scaling and diversification of growth. This, in turn, enhances success in cross-border operations, especially for knowledge-based sectors where transnational connections and social capital complement human capital.

Another engaging aspect of the book is Ray's depiction of women TEs across the transnational space. The text breaks new ground in migration scholarship by focusing on women navigating male-dominated corporate settings. The book highlights the gender-specific traits and vulnerabilities of women entrepreneurs, who have long remained invisible as transnational entrepreneurs from the global South, by sharing the stories of 15 women TEs. Through detailed case studies, Ray showcases the particular challenges female entrepreneurs face as they juggle substantial transnational economic pressures alongside deeply rooted domestic expectations. Ray shows that the mechanisms for cross-border ventures differ for many women TEs; social and institutional factors such as marital status, inheritance, a benevolent family structure, and religious affiliation more strongly support and shape self-efficacy and cross-entrepreneurial outcomes. For example, Ray highlights stories like Devyani's, an entrepreneur who rejoined her progressive business family in Kolkata following a failed marriage. Drawing on her skills, family connections, and international experience, Devyani built a multi-crore, export-focused company. Through accounts like hers, the book shows how migration can sometimes give women opportunities to reshape their life prospects, share valuable resources, and gain both spatial and social mobility, even in the face of strict structural barriers. At the same time, Ray shares stories like Sri's: a billionaire tech founder who rose from a humble rural village to lead a cloud software company serving thousands globally. Remarkably, Sri attributes his entrepreneurial success not to his Western degrees but to his modest rural Indian education, and he intentionally uses his platform to create economic opportunities for rural youth. Through these contrasting stories, Ray offers a nuanced perspective on the interplay between individual agency and structural influences.

Ray's critique of the 'transnational economic space' is central to the book's academic value. She contests the flat-world thesis promoted by supporters of globalisation, showing that transnationalism is a rugged, uneven landscape not to be taken for granted. Entrepreneurs must continually adapt to shifting legal systems, immigration barriers, and political volatility in both Washington and New Delhi. The book details how these business owners navigate anxieties over visas, fluctuating trade policies, and the emotional toll of maintaining bi-cultural family lives separated by thousands of miles. By focusing on these fractures, *Becoming Boundless* shows that being 'boundless' is not a permanent state of effortless mobility. It is a continuous, labour-intensive process of bridging systemic gaps, managing structural vulnerabilities, and negotiating power relations. The three empirical chapters examine theories of how transnational networks form and configure themselves, highlighting the local and global conditions under which they become salient for specific outcomes.

Becoming Boundless draws on a masterful synthesis of ethnographic fieldwork, narrative interviews, and archival historical research. Ray dedicated ten years to studying the shifting dynamics of Indian capitalism and global trade policy. This longitudinal perspective enables her to compare individual biographical trajectories with major macro-level changes, such as evolving US immigration laws and India's ongoing economic liberalisation. Rather than portraying these entrepreneurs as isolated, overly individualistic capitalists, Ray emphasises how deeply they are rooted in interconnected corporate, family, and community networks. Her structural approach applies Bourdieu's concept of capital to show how existing privileges – such as elite Indian education, dominant caste position, and family wealth – are converted into international capital. The 'boundless' business is not built in a vacuum; it is

carefully embedded in local networks of trust, shared cultural roots, and institutional mechanisms that enable the efficient transfer of information, capital, ideas, and talent across borders.

Becoming Boundless is an essential text in sociology, migration studies, and international political economy, and it's a pleasure to read. It addresses an empirical gap by moving beyond traditional migration studies to offer a detailed analysis of highly educated, capital-rich transnational actors. Although it draws heavily on complex sociological theories, Ray's writing remains clear, engaging, and human. The individual case studies anchor the abstract theory, imparting an empathetic, narrative pulse to the book. It steers clear of binary extremes – either praising global capitalism or condemning it outright – focusing instead on a detailed examination of its internal contradictions, hierarchies, and areas of empowerment. Ultimately, *Becoming Boundless* by Manashi Ray offers an engaging look at twenty-first-century global capitalism. Ray effectively shows that the modern Indian transnational entrepreneur is not merely a product of globalisation but an active player in redefining India's role in the current multipolar world. By revealing the underlying structures of class, caste, and gender that influence cross-border interactions, Ray encourages readers to critically consider who is included in the global economy and on what terms. It is strongly recommended for scholars, policymakers, and anyone interested in understanding the human, structural, and institutional forces behind our interconnected world.

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